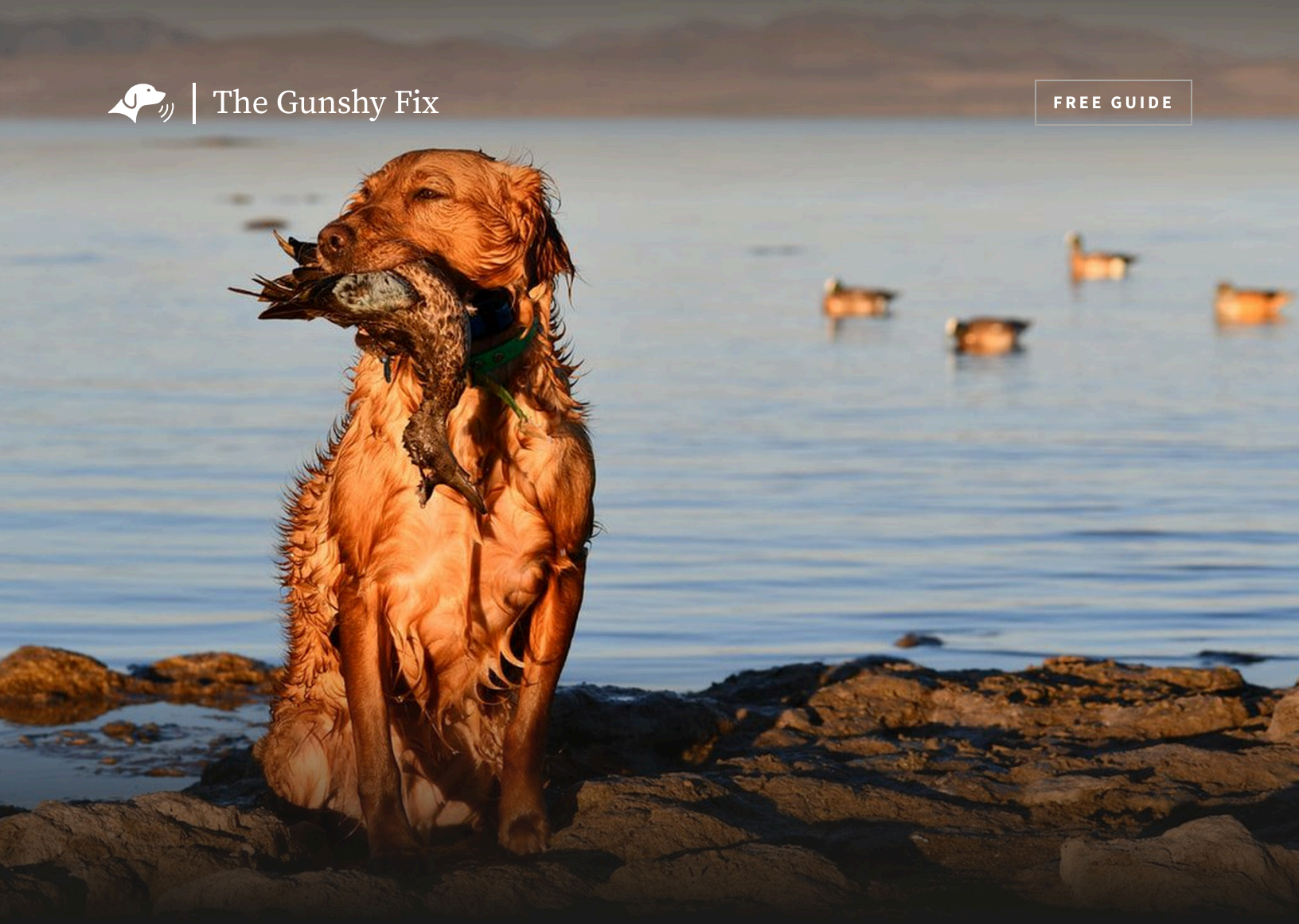
The Gunshy Fix

FREE GUIDE



FOR OWNERS OF A DOG THAT IS ALREADY GUN SHY

5 Things to Do Right Now If Your Dog Is Gun Shy

Calm, practical first steps from a professional bird dog trainer.
What to stop, what to start, and how to give your dog a real chance.

Tyce Erickson
Professional bird dog trainer
Utah Bird Dog Training, Payson, Utah

GUNSHYFIX.COM

A NOTE FROM TYCE

If your dog is scared of the gun, start here.

I train bird dogs for a living at Utah Bird Dog Training in Payson, Utah. One of the most common calls I get goes like this: the dog loved to hunt, then the gun came out, and everything changed.

If that is where you are, take a breath. A gun-shy dog is not a bad dog. Most of the time, the dog heard a shot before it was ready, too close or too soon, and now that sound means danger. That is an *association*, a link the dog has made in its mind between the sound and fear. Associations can often be changed, with patience.

This guide covers the five things I would do right now. None of them involve firing another shot to see what happens. They are about stopping the damage, rebuilding your dog's confidence, and setting up slow, steady work that gives your dog a real chance.

I can't promise every dog will be completely fixed. Nobody honest can. But the first moves matter a lot, and these are the ones I trust.

Tyce Erickson

Professional bird dog trainer, Utah Bird Dog Training



Tyce Erickson in the field with a bird dog.

THE 5 THINGS

1. Stop all gunfire around your dog
2. Stay calm and never force it
3. Rebuild the good stuff first
4. Bring sound back low and slow, paired with good things
5. Read your dog and let it set the pace

GUN SHY OR STARTLED?

A startle is not the same thing.

A startle

Your dog flinches at a shot, then goes right back to hunting or retrieving like nothing happened.

Gun shyness

Your dog's whole attitude changes. It quits, hides, heads for the truck, or stays glued to your leg.

1

FIRST, STOP THE DAMAGE

Stop all gunfire around your dog, starting today.

The first move is the simplest, and it is the one people skip most often. Stop shooting around your dog for now.

That means no more hunting trips “to see how he does,” no shooting range, no firing a shot in the yard to test her, and no tying the dog up while friends shoot. If your dog already links gunfire with fear, every extra scary experience gives that fear more proof. When you can, also limit other sudden booms like fireworks.

Write down what happened

How close was the gun? How old was the dog? Was it the first shot it ever heard? What did it do afterward? One bad moment is a different starting point than months of scary hunts, and knowing which one you have helps you decide how slowly to go.

TYCE’S RULE

Stopping the scary experiences won’t fix the problem by itself. It keeps you from digging a deeper hole.

2

YOUR REACTION MATTERS

Stay calm, and never force it.

Don’t force it. Never drag a scared dog toward a gun, hold it in place while someone shoots, or scold it for being afraid. Fear is an emotion, not disobedience. You can’t correct it out of a dog, and pressure usually makes it worse.

Let your dog step away. A dog that knows it can move away from a sound feels safer, and a dog that feels safe learns faster.

Don’t make a big fuss, either. If a noise startles your dog, stay relaxed and matter of fact. A calm hand or a quiet word is fine. What doesn’t help is a big, worried reaction from you. Dogs read our mood, and if you act like something terrible just happened, your dog may believe you.



3

POSITIVE FIRST, GUN LATER

Rebuild the good stuff first.



Before your dog hears another shot, rebuild the things it already loves. For most hunting dogs that means birds, retrieving, chasing, play, and food. At this stage there is **no gunfire at all**. You are simply getting your dog happy, busy, and confident again.

Retrievers

Build excitement with short, fun retrieves using a favorite bumper (a canvas or plastic training dummy). Quit while your dog still wants more.

Pointing dogs

Birds are often the best tool. Many trainers use a pigeon that can flutter but not fly off, so the dog can chase it and get fired up.

No birds?

Use what you have: retrieves, tug, a flirt pole (a toy on a rope you drag along the ground), and great food. Keep it fun.

Why movement helps

A dog that is running, chasing, or retrieving has something to focus on, and an outlet for nervous energy. That is why I would rather build the work around an activity the dog loves than have it sit still and wait for a noise.

Plan on several days here, or longer. There is no prize for rushing.

Ready to move on when your dog:

- [x] Shows strong interest in birds or retrieves
- [x] Is happy and full of energy
- [x] Chases and retrieves willingly
- [x] Has loose, normal body language
- [x] Is acting like itself again

4

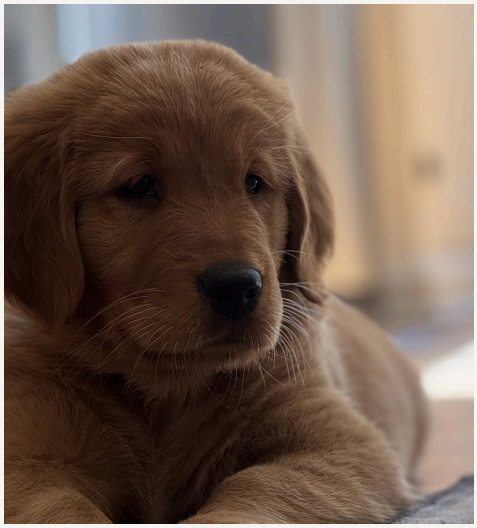
CONTROLLED SOUND WORK

Bring sound back low and slow, paired with good things.

Once your dog is happy and confident again, you can start bringing back the sound of gunfire, very carefully. Trainers call this *desensitization* and *counter-conditioning*. In plain terms: the sound starts so quiet your dog barely notices it, and it always comes with something your dog loves. Over time, the sound starts to mean good things are coming.

Start at home

- **Use a recording at a very low volume.** Lower than you think. If your dog reacts at all, it is too loud.
- **Add distance.** Play it from another room or across the yard, not right next to your dog.
- **Pair it with something great.** Dinner, a favorite chew, a game, calm petting. When the sound plays, the good stuff happens.
- **Keep sessions short.** A few minutes is plenty at first, in a quiet place where your dog already feels relaxed.
- **Turn it up in small steps,** and only after your dog has stayed completely relaxed for several sessions in a row.
- **If anything changes, turn it down.** Go back to the last level that was easy and stay there for a while.



Start somewhere your dog already feels safe and relaxed.

REMEMBER

If your dog stops eating, the sound is too loud or too close.

Later, in the field

Only when your dog stays relaxed with recorded gunfire at a realistic volume should you take the work outside. Have a helper do the shooting, a long way off, with the gun pointed away from your dog, while your dog is busy doing something it loves, like chasing a bird or a retrieve. I start live fire at least 200 yards away. If your dog hesitates, add distance right away. Never shoot over a dog that is still nervous.

5

YOUR DOG SETS THE PACE

Go slow, and read your dog's body language.

The distance and the volume are not the most important things to watch. Your dog is. The goal is not just a dog that doesn't run away. The goal is a dog that can hear the sound and keep acting like itself.

A scared dog doesn't always bolt. Some dogs stay glued to your leg, stop hunting, or simply go quiet. That still counts.



Relaxed KEEP GOING

- Loose, wiggly body
- Tail at its normal height and moving
- Eats and takes treats like usual
- Keeps chasing, retrieving, or hunting
- Ranges out the way it normally does
- Soft face and ears
- Settles quickly after a noise

Stressed BACK UP

- Tail tucked or held low, ears pinned back
- Lip licking, yawning, or panting when not hot or tired
- Trembling, freezing, or going stiff
- Won't eat or take treats
- Whites of the eyes showing
- Glued to your leg or walking behind you
- Quits working, leaves, or heads for the truck
- Watches the gun or speaker instead of the fun

When you see stress, do this

1. Stop the sound or turn it down right away.
2. Go back to the last step that was easy.
3. Stay there until your dog is itself again, for several sessions.
4. Then try a smaller step forward.

There is no calendar for this. Some dogs make good progress in a few weeks. Others take months. Going too fast is the easiest way to undo your progress, so when in doubt, slow down.

AVOID THESE

Common mistakes that set dogs back

1 "Testing" with another shot
Firing a gun to see if your dog is still scared can make the fear stronger. Trust what you have already seen.

2 Hoping a hunt will fix it
Taking a nervous dog hunting and hoping it "gets over it" usually gives the fear more proof.

3 Skipping steps
Cranking the volume or jumping ahead because a session went well. Progress comes from small steps repeated.

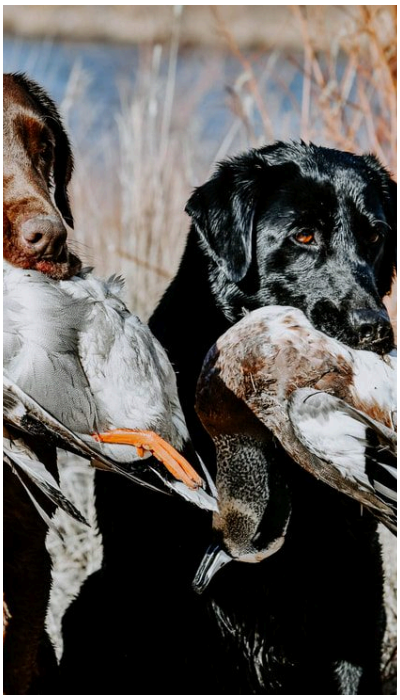
4 Forcing or correcting fear
Holding a dog in place, dragging it closer, or scolding it. Fear is not disobedience.

5 Bad timing
Playing gun sounds when your dog is already anxious, or during stressful training. Start when your dog is relaxed.

6 Giving up after one bad day
Setbacks are normal. Go back a step, rebuild, and keep going.

7 Bringing the gun close too soon
Even when your dog is improving, keep live fire far off and pointed away. Close shots come last.

8 Racing the calendar
Hunting season is not a deadline for your dog. Its pace matters more than the opener.



REALISTIC EXPECTATIONS

An honest word before you start

There is no guaranteed cure for gun shyness, and I won't pretend there is. How a dog responds depends on how strong the fear is, what caused it, how much the dog loves birds and retrieving, and how patiently the work is done.

Dogs that still want the bird or the retrieve, had one bad experience rather than many, and have an owner willing to stop shooting around them often have a good starting point. Dogs with a long history of close shots, or very little drive, are harder.

Expect good days and setbacks. If your dog's fear seems severe, spreads to other noises, or includes panic like trying to escape, talk with your veterinarian as well. Some dogs need extra help, and that is okay.



YOUR NEXT STEP

Ready for the full step-by-step plan?

This guide covers the first moves. The Gunshy Fix 8-Lesson Audio Program walks you through the sound work one lesson at a time, so you always know what to play next and when to slow down.

Gunshy Fix 8-Lesson Audio Program

- Eight MP3 lessons, about 32 minutes each
- Lesson 1 is music only. Each lesson after that adds gunfire a little more.
- Play on any speaker: in the crate, the kennel, or the yard
- Clear instructions for when to move forward, when to back up, and how to take it to the field
- Built by Tyce Erickson, a working bird dog trainer at Utah Bird Dog Training

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